

3.1.4 Area of study 2: Popular music

For the purpose of this specification, popular music is defined as mainstream music including a number of musical styles and genres including rock, pop, musical theatre, film and computer gaming music from 1950 to the present.

Listening – unfamiliar music

Students must be able to listen attentively to unfamiliar music from the following styles/genres to identify and accurately describe musical elements, musical contexts and musical language:

- music of Broadway 1950s to 1990s
- rock music of 1960s and 1970s
- film and computer gaming music 1990s to present
- pop music 1990s to present.

Study piece

Little Shop of Horrors 1982 off-Broadway version – the following three tracks:

- *Prologue/Little Shop of Horrors (overture)*
- *Mushnik and Son*
- *Feed Me* (*Sudden Changes* material is not part of the stated set work)

(first teaching 2020, first assessment 2022, final assessment 2025)

Queen – the following three tracks:

- *Bohemian Rhapsody*
- *The Seven Seas of Rhye*
- *Love of my Life*

(first taught 2024, first assessed 2026)

Musical elements

In addition to the musical elements listed for Area of study 1, students must know and understand musical elements appropriate to this Area of study.

The following table contains all the musical elements, for this area of study, that students must know and understand to answer questions in section A (Listening) and section B (Study piece). Marks will also be awarded for knowledge of other terms if relevant to this area of study in section B (Study piece) of the exam.

Element type	Element
Melody	• riff • pitch bend • melisma • hook • slide • glissando • improvisation • ostinato • blue notes.
Harmony	• power chords • chord symbols eg C⁷ • stock chord progressions eg I VI IV V.
Tonality	• pentatonic • modal • blues scale.
Structure	• intro/outro • verse • chorus • break • twelve-bar blues • drum fill.

Element type	Element
Sonority (Timbre)	• standard contemporary instrument types eg electric guitar, synthesisers • specific instrument types eg sitar, dilruba • instrumental techniques eg palm mute (pm), pitch bend, hammer-on (ho), pull-off (po), slide guitar/bottleneck • drum kit components and techniques eg rim shot • vocal timbres eg falsetto, belt, rap, beat-boxing, scat singing • specific instrumental techniques eg slap bass • specific instrumental effects eg amplification, distortion • specific technological recording techniques eg automatic double-tracking (ADT) and direct input transformer (DIT).
Tempo, metre and rhythm	• bpm (beats per minute) • mm (metronome marking) • groove • backbeat • syncopation • off-beat • shuffle, swing/swung.